

"more pressured with the national team than with Real Madrid". It was because he wanted to "take the name of Portugal as far as possible".

Diego Maradona, now coach of Argentina, spelt out just what the Cup was about as he landed in South Africa and announced, "I have seen the player who will inherit my place in Argentine football and his name is Messi." Those words leave Lionel Messi with a direct view of the chasm at his feet. Messi, 23, has 34 goals this season, a history of La Liga, Spanish Cup, Champions League titles, an Olympic gold medal and the World Player of the Year Award and still he says, "All I have done can be exceeded by winning the World Cup".

In fiction or film, maybe one of Africa's six countries at the Cup would be able to have what Messi, Ronaldo, Brazil's Robinho and England's Rooney are closer to. At the moment,

African STARS

The Cup is a chance for the leading lights to shine



>> Samuel Eto'o Fils
Cameroon

> Didier Drogba
Ivory Coast



Photography AP

BRAZILIAN PLAYERS PRACTICE DURING A TRAINING SESSION IN JOHANNESBURG

3.4 mn tickets have been sold for 64 matches of the World Cup in South Africa. TV rights have been sold for \$3.4 billion.

though, the continent's power is to be found in its influx of more than 250 players into the highest leagues in England, Spain, Italy, France, Germany, the Netherlands and Portugal. Africa could use this glitter for a little more shine. The Cup can

give to the world an African statement far removed from the tragic attack on the Togolese team during their Nations Cup. It can add a louder chorus to the talents of Drogba, E'to and Kanu.

But what could a team like North Korea, so distanced from everything, possibly do? Its striker Jong Tae Se, who plays pro football in Japan, smiles at the idea of rubbing shoulders with the Brazilians or shaking hands with Cristiano. His team have trained in secret for six months, who knows at what altitude. He told a newspaper that he knew the world would "coff" when asked about our team.

Then I say to myself, 'Go on

laughing. Laugh at us more. Miracles can happen'."

A decade ago, a World Cup in Africa itself would have been thought of as a miracle. In the matter of days, hours, it will be upon us and on them, the men who dance with a globe glued to their feet. The lights at the 94,700-seater Johannesburg Soccer City stadium will be switched on and we will be flooded by football.

Then the numbers will come pouring out. Eight groups, 32 teams, 64 matches, 214 countries watching on 376 TV channels, 1,600 players and support staff, 5,61,200 total South African stadium capacity. Yet the only number that billions transfixed on TV and the 736 footballers will care about are the most minimalist.

Two digits: 1-0, the happy bubble of victory, 1-2 code for extra time heart-break, 4-5 a crushing tie-breaker.

Strip away everything else and it is what football, in a muddy neighbourhood park or atop the gleaming pyramid, will always be about—the pursuit of goal.

After all, the World Cup is the showpiece of the world's biggest and most basic game. It is Brazil and North Korea dressed in a single jersey. ■